These guys were poaching. All those conducted tours to the US installations were to impress me about the facilities the US has against a country like India struggling to understand the basics of space science. There was no doubt that they had impressed me, but I could not wait to get back to India where Sarabhai waited with his dreams—and my wife and son with theirs.

I called Sarabhai.

'Leave the nasty guys and take the next flight,' he said.

I remember Sarabhai adding that he would speak to Arnold Frutkin. The name didn't ring a bell till I realised later that Frutkin, the man who Sarabhai wanted to give a piece of his mind to, was the deputy director of NASA's International Programs Office during the US's space race with the USSR. Later he was designated the associate administrator for external relations. With Sarabhai gone, only Frutkin, still alive at 98 at the time of writing this, would know what Sarabhai told him about the American poaching attempt.

I returned to India in September 1970.